



Vernacular Vocabulary Restored

When Anjali Mangalgiri of Goa-based Grounded acquired a 160-year-old Portuguese house in the quiet village of Aldona, the instinct that most would have followed—clear it, start clean—never entered the conversation. Her team documented everything first, with every opening catalogued and piece of timber assessed, to map the Goan-Portuguese vernacular vocabulary before a single intervention was planned. The result, completed in 2025, is a contemporary family home that reads as a love letter.

Existing red-oxide floors were restored and paired with lime-plaster walls and reclaimed teak. Iron window grills became gates. The balcao was disassembled and rebuilt further out to frame a new garden and stone pool; the same structure, in a new conversation with the land. The prayer niche in the central room, likely vandalised by a previous owner, was repaired and returned to its place. It now watches over the eat-in kitchen, a solemn presence among people who didn't know it was there before them.

What Grounded has also done, quietly, is absorb the legal complexity that typically keeps buyers away from heritage property in Goa; titles with 20-plus owners, documentation in archaic Portuguese, inheritance lines under a colonial civil code. The poetic and the practical, for once, in the same hands.

PLOT TWIST
(clockwise from below) Living spaces by groupDCA; Grounded; Studio Tilt; Grounded; and exteriors of Casa Hypotenuse, Gurgaon by Renesa Architecture Design Interiors

Sanctuary for Books and Beings

In Siolim (Goa), a short drive north, Studio Tilt co-founders Natasha Kumar and Abhijit Sawant encountered a structure with almost no legible history; possibly a barn, possibly animal storage. Where another practice might have treated that ambiguity as a licence to start afresh, they treated it as a kind of freedom.

Their clients, literary agent Hemali Sodhi and HarperCollins India CEO Ananth Padmanabhan, had asked for a home that reflected who they actually were: people for whom books, animals, and time spent entirely in nature constituted the primary luxuries. The architects responded by treating the existing site as something to work around rather than clear. Every plant was retained. The bougainvillea pergola at the entry, its supports already deeply entwined with roots too established to disturb, was preserved and built around. Throughout construction, the rescue animals from the adjacent welfare shelter continued their daily routes uninterrupted. "We would be greeted every day by rescued dogs, rabbits and ducks," Kumar recalls.



Photograph by JEETIN SHARMA